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Final Exam: International Security

#3 Prompt

Public opinions regarding international security issues have the capacity to influence international security policy through perceptions regarding norms, treaties, and order. Although international security and the hierarchy surrounding it is “created by and privilege the powerful”¹, the public can influence the actions and behaviors taken by the powerful. This paper will examine how the public’s perception of the order, norms and of treaties impacts international security decisions, which in turn may shape the public’s opinions.

To understand the relationship between public perception on international security issues and international security itself, it is important to highlight, examine and define key terms surrounding this topic. The definition of the term *norm*, shall be Krasner’s who described it as, “standards of behavior defined in terms of rights and obligation, “provide an intersubjective context in which discourse and behavior are interpreted and either condoned or condemned by third parties”.² *Covert intervention* or *covertness* is a military strategy which states choose to employ in order to limit the escalation of war, by avoiding domestic pressures.³ Another term used in this paper is *mobilized dissent*, which Conrad and Ritter (2019) explain as a group of non-state actors who attempt to alter a government’s political activity.⁴ To be able to examine the public’s perception on order, Bapat’s (2019) definition of hegemony as a hierarchical structure wherein a singular state establishes an economic and militaristic standard which other states must align with, provides insight.⁵

The public’s perception of the hierarchical structure and idea of an order may influence a state’s foreign policymaking process. There have been many varying instances in American foreign policy, where the public’s perception of another state impacts the relations between the two governments. This is primarily an effect of labeling another state as an Other, which differs from the Self. The public characterizes the Other with assumptions which are biased and not fully accurate, in turn being misleading and create a polarizing relationship between the two states.⁶ For example, this can be noted in the relationship between China and the United States. In 2015, there was an increase found in “English-media references... to China’s challenge to the

¹ (Goddard, 2018, “Embedded Revisionism: Networks, Institutions and World Order”, 765)

² ” (Carpenter, 2003, “Women and Children First: Gender, Norms and Humanitarian Evacuation in the Balkans 1991-95, 670)

³ ” (Carson, 2020, *Secret Wars: Covert Conflict in International Politics*)

⁴ .(Conrad & Ritter, 2019, “Contentious Compliance, Dissent and Repression under International Human Rights Law”, 9)

⁵ (Bapat, 2019, *Monsters to Destroy: Understanding the War on Terror*)

⁶ (Breuer & Johnson, 2019, “Memes, Narratives and the Emergent U.S.-China Security Dilemma)

Rules-based order.”⁷ This idea of China as a challenger to the U.S. hegemony and order was circulated widely amongst the public, leading to a certain political and social atmosphere which was antagonistic towards China, resulting in more tense relations with China. This leads to American international security becoming more militaristic and economically harsher in relations to China. Another example of the public’s opinions towards international security issues influencing American foreign policy and international security was American engagement in the Middle East. Motivated to solve domestic economic struggles, the American government decided to enter into a deal with Saudi Arabia to ensure that the American Dollar would be the currency used in oil trade. While this satisfied the American government, there was a desire to keep the deal hidden from the American public due to a desire to avoid the public being aware of the fact that the economy had been dangerously weak and that America - the hegemon – was relying on “foreign states, particularly Arab states” as there was domestic worry that American foreign policy would be influenced and controlled by foreign powers.⁸ This decision to keep this deal from the American public was bound by a shared worry, by both the American government and the Saudi government, that this deal would be damaging to both sides, in their respective ways.⁹ Based on both examples it can be understood that the American public’s perception of relationships with perceived agitators influenced the American government into either hiding a deal from the public or escalating tensions with the supposed agitator. In both cases, America is seeking to preserve the status quo of its power of the order it ‘leads’.¹⁰

The public’s perception towards norms impacts international security, as it enforces a certain behavior. This can be noted as in the creation and implementation of the civilian immunity norms. Initially a vast array of ethical and moral ideas, it has since “been codified into treaty law that is now considered a part of customary international law”¹¹ The power of the public’s opinion that civilians should be protected during times of war in areas which are experiencing conflict, can be highlighted by the American society’s expression of anger upon learning that the United States had violated laws of conduct, which resulted in an effort to decrease civilian casualties, reflecting the public’s opinion.¹²

The opinion of the public and its perception of international security issues can be noted in the implementation and enforcement of treaties. It has been found that the American public is largely for the American government being in line with international

⁷ (Johnston, 2019, “China in a World of Orders: Rethinking Compliance and Challenge in Beijing’s International Relations, 9-10)

⁸ (Bapat, 2019, *Monsters to Destroy: Understanding the War on Terror*, 22)

⁹ (Carson, 2020, *Secret Wars: Covert Conflict in International Politics*, 3)

¹⁰ Carson, 2020, *Secret Wars: Covert Conflict in International Politics*, 11)

¹¹ (Carpenter & Montgomery, 2020, “The Stopping Power of Norms”, 20)

¹² (Carpenter & Montgomery, 2020, “The Stopping Power of Norms”, 23)

laws.¹³ Moreover, this can also be noted in another study conducted in Australia which also found that its constituency prefers and wants its government to follow international law. However, it does make specific mention of the Australian public caring more of international law violations when it impacts the reputation of Australia on an international level.¹⁴

To ensure that the public is informed and not misconstruing its opinions and perceptions towards international security issues, it is important to be aware of the nuances and implications of one's perceptions and opinions. Furthermore, it is important to be aware of how one's perception and opinion may be influenced and be whom it may be influenced. For example, understanding the connection between the fact that since women both studying international security and are participating in international security issues are underestimated and therefore power and policymaking are gendered leads to "greater national insecurity".¹⁵ The public should seek out well-rounded and diverse information and knowledge.

Overall, the public's perception around international security issues has the capability to influence international security decisions by the state.

¹³ (Carpenter & Montgomery, 2020, "The Stopping Power of Norms", 23)

¹⁴ (Sheppard & von Stein, 2022, "Attitudes and Action in International Refugee Policy: Evidence from Australia", 950)

¹⁵ (Thomas, 2021, "Women's Participation in Political Violence", 2)